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John Altman

John Altman has fashioned an impressive career as an instrumentalist, big band arranger, popular music producer, and film and television composer. He has been a key member of the music business in London, New York, and Los Angeles.

John was interviewed via Zoom on September 14, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and it's a great pleasure to have John Altman with me today, from one continent to the other.

JA: Yup. Delighted to be here.

MR: I was reading lengthy descriptions of your career and watching videos and this phrase came into my head and I'm going to try it out on you. And the phrase is John Altman is the Quincy Jones of England, and Quincy Jones is the John Altman of America.

JA: Oh I'm very flattered. I was introduced to him by Benny Carter who I used to spend every Thursday with when I was in Los Angeles. And he kept saying to me, "Do you know Quincy Jones?" And I went I know who he is but I don't know him. And the following week he'd say, "Do you know Quincy Jones?" And I thought you know I've got to make allowances, he's 90 something and getting on and maybe he doesn't remember what I said last time. Then he had a birthday party and he sat me next to Quincy Jones so I knew there was a method in his madness.

MR: I'm trying to imagine what you and Quincy Jones would talk about. I had made an assumption early on in this project that musicians when they get together always talk about music. And then I overheard a conversation once with Frank Wess and Joe Williams and a number of other fellas like that and they weren't talking about music at all.

JA: Yeah. Well funny enough the great thing about talking with Quincy was I happened to mention Lucky Thompson straight off the bat which of course set him off. And all he wanted to talk about was the Lionel Hampton band and Clifford Brown and Jimmy Cleveland and it was, I'm sure everybody else at the table, I mean it was a big event. And we talked the whole evening. And I don't think we got any later than 1956. And it was wonderful you know because I suppose nobody ever spoke to him about that anymore you know it was always Michael Jackson or "Off the Wall" or one of those sort of events. So to go back and have somebody mention Lucky Thompson and Clifford Brown and Gigi Gryce was quite a shock I think.

MR: Well I want to go back with you because I read that you came from a musical family and your uncles were in the business. Were you fascinated early on by — how much did you witness of what they did and was it something that seemed like oh yes, I want to do that.

JA: Yeah it was very interesting. I mean my older — I mean there were four brothers and they were all band leaders and they all played different instruments. And two of them became — I would say sort of household names in England certainly but also, surprisingly, in America. My uncle Sid Phillips was our leading arranger and jazz clarinet player. He wound up playing with Louis Armstrong's U.K. All-Stars. But he'd gone to New York for Irving Mills. He was the Ambrose band arranger which was a very popular dance band both here and in the States. And Irving Mills, who had his publishing, invited him to New York where he recorded with an amazing — I've got the recordings — an amazing New York session band which is basically a Saturday night swing club band. But he also was jamming with Bunny Berigan and Bobby Hackett and Bud Freeman. And he actually introduced Artie Shaw to Buddy Rich, whom he heard playing in a club with I think it might have been Bobby Hackett or Adrian Rollini or someone like that. And he said to Artie Shaw, "Oh you want to hire this guy, he's really great." And he also convinced Chappel's, the publishers, to take on Jerry Gray, who they'd never heard of, before all the Glenn Miller stuff, so a very interesting guy. And after the war he led Britain's leading Dixieland band and then my youngest uncle, Will Phillips, conducted at London Palladium so he actually conducted the band for Duke Ellington and Benny Goodman. So the union regulations, they weren't allowed to bring their own bands. So Duke Ellington played with my uncle's band with him leading it. So Ellington would thereafter introduce him as my band leader.

MR: Wow, where do you go from there?

JA: Where do you go from there? And my childhood acquaintances were Nat King Cole and Judy Garland and the Andrews Sisters and Sophie Tucker, Jack Benny. So without knowing who they were, I was being imbued with this culture of music, you know, show business, music. And it just seemed like a natural thing to me. And then I would see my uncles playing music on television, because they appeared a lot on British T.V. And somewhere it was always, well you know I think I want to do that. It was never any question that I wouldn't be playing an instrument.

MR: Were your parents on board with that direction they saw you going in?

JA: Oh yeah. I mean my mother played wonderful stride piano which she learned by looking over her brother's shoulder. And my youngest uncle learned to arrange by looking over his brother's shoulder. So at the age of 14 he was writing for the Ambrose Band which is quite extraordinary. He was a staff arranger at Lawrence Wright at the age of 14. So there's a musical gene in the family that runs all the way through to my kids to my cousin

was the drummer with Toto for 30-odd years. You know it's gone all the way through and carried on which is amazing.

MR: Was the saxophone your first choice of instruments?

JA: I started playing piano when I was seven and I had lessons 'til the age of eleven and then I stopped because I changed teacher and the teacher basically said well you're doing everything incorrectly, you know your posture is wrong, your hand position is wrong, your timing is wrong. We're going to start again from the beginning and I wasn't having any of that. So I gave up the piano and at the age of twelve, thirteen, I just thought I want to play the saxophone. And my uncle brought round the sort of cheap Selmer and showed me what to do on the Friday night, and on the Saturday night I played the gig.

MR: Aw come on. You can't make this stuff up.

JA: Well I already played the recorder you see.

MR: Okay so you had sort of a sense.

JA: Where one's fingers went you know. But I can't even imagine what I played. I think "Green Onions" in the key of — concert key of E you know was about the limit I could manage.

MR: I was curious, there's anecdotes that you've shared about, probably not that long after that, sitting in with some of the now-well-known rock bands. You'd go to a club and, did you have to like make your way through the bouncers and the manager or whatever?

JA: No the interesting thing is there weren't any in those days, and we're talking about, you know, bands like Fleetwood Mac and John Mayall's Bluesbreakers and even the Jimi Hendrix Experience would be playing in local bars, you know, in the back room or upstairs. There were no dressing rooms let alone bouncers. And you'd see someone at the bar and you'd take your tenor along, or I'd take my tenor along, and I'd say, "Can I play with you?" And quite usually they would say yeah, sure. And it wasn't a case of well we know who you are so come and join us. It was more a case of well we'll give you one tune and if you're no good we'll kick you off. And if you can play we'll ask you to stay for the whole evening. And once you got to know them you'd play maybe one solo or something and they went, "Oh this guy's all right." At the end of the evening they'd say we're playing another club next Saturday, why don't you join us — or I've got another band, come and play with them, or my friend's band is so-and-so, tell them that you played with us and join in. So I built up this whole circle of jamming and I always say I was very lucky because I went to University on a full grant. So I didn't need to turn professional, I could go and jam with whoever I felt like and it wasn't an economic necessity to go on tour with a soul band or play in a holiday camp for the whole summer. I would show up at gigs or even at University, my roommate was social secretary so I got him to book all the people I could play with.

MR: Nice deal. When you got up on the stage, would they usually call one of their originals or would they do like a blues or something?

JA: It would be a blues mainly, yes. And then you basically would be in that position where I mean obviously a lot of people would get up and they would try and show off, because they would go oh I've got two choruses to show that I'm a genius. You know? I never had that feeling. I always felt well I've got to fit in and contribute to what they're doing. Therefore I'm going to play, you know, within myself but make it musical and make it make sense. I always had that notion in my head, that I would do that rather than, you know, show off or do something technical that people'd go wow, he's technically good.

MR: Yeah. Or cover up a singer.

JA: Oh yeah, no that was the other thing. I mean I was actually on one gig where the singer turned to me and said, "Can you please go and shut that other guy up?" He won't stop playing you know. So I was very lucky I think you know, to build up that series of contacts before I actually knew that I was going to go professional.

MR: And then I'm going to guess that down the road you crossed paths again with some of these same musicians in a different context?

JA: Oh always, yes. I mean very early on I, as a sax player, I decided that it'd be a good idea to learn to play the flute and clarinet, not because I wanted to be in a big band or anything like that, but if I played the flute I could go to a folk club and play with the up-and-coming Mick Drakes and John Martins and people like that who populated the London folk scene. And if I played the clarinet I could do Dixieland gigs, which I started doing though it was very schizophrenic you know. One day I'd be on the blues scene or even the same day, then I'd go to a folk club and then I'd do a Dixieland gig later on. But I was voracious. I loved music. Music was everywhere.

MR: You were getting on-the-job training for your composing and your arranging.

JA: Certainly. Yeah.

MR: Like it all was going into your head.

JA: Very interesting story — there was a bass player in London called John Hart, who was part of, I believe he was part of the Woolworth family so at that time he was very well off and had a very large house in one of the best parts of London. And Philly Joe Jones came to live with him. It was extraordinary. I mean I think it was because there was access to drugs on the National Health you know. So he could register as an addict and he didn't have to be hounded by the police or anything like that. But he took up residence in this house in Hampstead. And he couldn't work because he didn't have a permit, but he could teach and he could run jam sessions. So I got invited at the age of 16 to a jam session. And I'd been playing for three years and there were the best horn players in the country, all lining up, all trying to impress Philly Joe Jones. And we started playing a blues and it

got to me and I was panicking. I was going I can't do a five chorus Coltrane impersonation you know, what am I going to do? Oh, I'll play one note. I'll play it again and add another one. Oh I'll play it again, the third one, and then I'll invert it — hang on a minute, this is what you do. And at the end of the number he came over to me and he said, "You play like Joe Henderson." He ignored everybody else and came over — and I thought now I understand improvisation. Now I know what the musicality of being an improviser actually is, rather than oh I've got sixteen ways to get from a D major 7 to a G without playing every substitution in the book. So it was on-the-job. And as a coda to that, several years later, obviously on the advice of Philly Joe, Hank Mobley showed up in this house.

MR: Ah, one of my favorites.

JA: Me too. And I got a phone call from John Hart, who sadly we lost very young in a car crash. And he rang me and said, "Hank Mobley would like to borrow your tenor." And I said oh. He said, "Yes, he's arrived, he hasn't brought one." I said, "Oh what reeds and mouthpiece has he got?" And he said, "No he brought nothing, he wants the lot." I said no. Not for me, and I passed.

MR: You passed? I think I would too.

JA: Well Ronnie Scott wound up lending him a horn you know, but in later years I told the story to Jimmy Heath and he said to me, "Oh you'd never have seen that again."

MR: It would have found its way to a pawn shop, ey?

JA: Yes exactly. And he said, I won't name the wonderful tenor player that Jimmy named but I'm sure you can guess who it was, he said he used to borrow my horn, I used to go to the gig, stand at the side of the stage and walk home with him.

MR: So you had a free ticket at a university yet if this is correct you gave it up to go with Hot Chocolate? Is that correct?

JA: That was a couple of years later. I came back to London and was doing a research degree and then I got a phone call asking if I'd like to join the group Hot Chocolate who at the time were the number one singles band after The Beatles. And I don't know if I thought — well that's my next profession or anything like that. I thought oh that would be fun to do a year or a tour or a couple of tours with them, which it turned out to be two years of great fun.

MR: Did you find that in that situation you kept getting asked to do more things and you just figured out how to do them?

JA: Pretty much, yes. Because looking back now it's very interesting because it's all around the same time I'd done some playing — I started recording when I was 19 which seems ridiculous because I was still at University. But I recorded with the Monty Python team in 1973 and got sort of sucked into their inner circle. So I was with them. I was arranging

very simplistically for records and having some success. I was arranging Hot Chocolate stage act. I then started writing for the BBC doing take-downs because I had a very good ear and in those days acts like The Stylistics for example, or country artists would come to England and they wouldn't bring any music. They probably didn't have it. They hadn't been to their recording sessions so if there was a full string section on the record I would have to listen to the record and adapt it for whatever show they were coming to do. So all these things were going on at the same time, and then I started writing for commercials.

MR: You used the word "take-downs." Are you meaning like using your ear to take something off the record and re-create it?

JA: Yes. I would get a cassette from the record company and first of all I would write down what I heard on the record. And then I would adapt it for whatever show they were going on. So if they went on a variety show and they said we've only got two woodwinds or something like that, I would then condense the arrangement to fit that line-up. That was an interesting time.

MR: Were you able to ask your uncles about this arranging, like gee a tenor sax sounds — where does it sound actually on the staff and the minutiae of arranging and knowing how to use instruments?

JA: I mean it sounds awful to say, but it was just something I always knew. I mean even when I was seven years old I would hear maybe a symphony and go, "Oh, there's a bassoon doubling the cellos but it stops after eight bars." "Oh hello, there's a flute and a clarinet in octave unisons." So I never had an arranging lesson in my life and I didn't read a book. I mean I eventually got a book just to make sure what on earth I was doing might work, and I just looked in the book, I think it's the Walter Piston book, and I went well hang on a minute, I know that. Well I do that anyway. Well why am I reading the book?

MR: Like the piano lesson. "You're doing this wrong." But did you, at that time you would have been using a pencil and a score pad.

JA: Yeah.

MR: Did you write your scores in concert key or were they transposed already?

JA: No I wrote them in concert. I still do.

MR: I still do.

JA: I still do.

MR: At what point were you lucky enough to get a copyist?

JA: Really early on actually, because I became the sort of arranger-in-chief for a band called the Pasadena Roof Orchestra, who were a 1920s revival band. And they did a lot of either original songs of the '20s, or takedowns of McKinney's Cotton Pickers or early Ellington. And I'd do both. I'd do original arrangements from scratch, but I'd also take down classic big band charts. When I say big band I mean pre-Swing Era charts. And

their tuba player did all the copying. And he became my copyist basically through forty-odd years. So I was never writing music just for the sake of writing music. I was always employed to do stuff. And in fact the Pasadena Roof Orchestra were hired to do the music for a film called "Just a Gigolo" which starred the totally unlikely combination of David Bowie and Marlene Dietrich. So if you can get your head round that, you can get your head round — it was a terrible film. But basically I was arranging 1920s songs that were fairly obscure some of them. And when I saw the film they peppered the whole film with my music so it became the score of the film. That was my introduction to movies. "Oh here it comes again for the fourth time." "Oh there's a love scene, it's playing behind that, well I didn't write it for that but what the hell."

MR: Ah, you're anticipating a question I'm going to ask later about music and emotions and all that, but I wanted to talk briefly about — do you call them jingles?

JA: Yeah they can be. I don't feel that I was particularly a jingle composer, although I have written a couple that have been successful on that front. But mainly there was all the mini-movies with directors like Ridley Scott, Hugh Hudson, Alan Parker, John Frankenheimer, and then great photographers like Elliot Erwitt and David Bailey and Terrence Donovan. And my lyricist on a few was Salmon Rushdie.

MR: Oh my God. Well I'm talking about selling products.

JA: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. So if a representative of an ad agency is having a meeting with you and they're selling paper towels, did you have to learn how to interpret the way they spoke about music into actual music?

JA: Oh absolutely. And I think very helpful for that was my academic background in English literature. Because I was always looking to try and comprehend subtext of anything that people said. And what was always very interesting was you would often get people saying, "I want a jazz track." And that could mean Louis Armstrong or it could mean Ornette Coleman. You know, I want something classical. Is that Bach or is that Stravinsky? I want country & western. Do you mean a hoedown or do you mean Dolly Parton? It's very interesting. You are constantly trying to narrow people's focus. So if I would go in for a meeting, and you would, you know, sometimes get "Could you make it green?" or I mean you get some very funny comments that I tried to keep away from the musicians because they would all burst out laughing. So I would try to keep them out of the control room. I mean one when they actually did come in, sadly, was for processed cheese. And I said to the director, "What do you think?" He said, "Well I may be wrong but it seems to start at the beginning and go all the way through very nicely until the end, when it stops." I said, "Yes, that's about the only way I know how to write music I'm afraid. But you know he's chording a lot on the bottom string and somebody said to the

guitarist, "If I heard a noise in my head could you play it?" And he said, "Well actually I had five years medical training, I could probably cure it."

MR: I love it.

JA: Yes. Very funny.

MR: Were they normally like 30-second —

JA: Yes, 30-second, 60-second, 40-second, 10-second, 5-second.

MR: Is it harder to write a 10-second spot than a 30-second spot?

JA: Well you really have to, you know, it's a bit like the playing thing that I mentioned earlier. You have to pare your focus right down into that precise moment. I mean it is a very interesting thing to do, and particularly like there's a lot for New York, and my contact was Elliott Lawrence. So Elliott would come over to London, and of course I'd be talking to him about Johnny Mandel and Al Cohn and Gerry Mulligan, and he'd say, "Well yes, we've got this Ford commercial to do." And I said, "Yeah, never mind that, what about Benny Goodman?" It was very interesting.

MR: Did you ever get carried away with, you're working on a 30-second spot and you write something that you really like and you start adding and expanding and then an alarm goes off and it says all right, remember your task here, maybe set this aside and make something out of it later?

JA: Not so much that, but I did write things that almost got thrown away on — I remember I wrote one thing for a week-long campaign for a national newspaper. It was a special campaign. And I always really liked it. So when I got to score a silent movie for the London Film Festival, years later, I dredged it up and used it in that. You know so more that. I mean I was always focused on the task in hand. In fact there was one commercial I got to shadow, they hired Sir Michael Tippitt to compose but they asked me to be in the background advising him no don't do that, which was very weird until the moment when he actually turned to me and said, "I have no idea how to write a 28-second piece." He said, "I can't do it, I just can't do it." And I wound up adapting two pieces of William Walton that bore no relevance to each other that I thought well, I mean this isn't going to go. And of course the Walton estate gave their permission straight away I think because of the money that was involved rather than the artistic merit of what I'd done.

MR: Do you get residuals or payments after the fact for any of this kind of work?

JA: Yeah. Residuals. Obviously they're more short term because the campaigns don't last years and years and years generally. But I always got a healthy residual for anything that I did write. Not as much as the voiceovers but —

MR: I see.

JA: But there were some amazing voiceovers, you know people would come in and you'd be in awe of who showed up. Or singers, you know I did one with Eartha Kitt, I did one with

Mel Torme. It's amazing to look back and think well, we did this commercial for soap or breakfast cereal and they flew Eartha Kitt into London. And she called me "sir."

MR: You know I considered doing that because I wonder, that I think you probably should get a knighthood, don't you?

JA: I don't know. I'm happy with what I've got.

MR: You were — there's some marvelous interviews online that I have watched and I think you were describing a scene from a James Bond movie. And you used the word absurd. So I started thinking about adjectives and what goes through your head after you watch a sequence, even before you go to the piano or have a pencil in hand that might musicalize an adjective like absurd?

JA: Well I mean taking for example that particular sequence, which I know is the GoldenEye tank chase. I had arranged and conducted the whole score for another composer. And when they did the — came to dub the film, they basically weren't happy with what he'd written and they contacted me and said would you write something for this. And I said well I know what you want but I won't do it unless the composer is happy, because I'm his arranger. And they phoned him and he — I think grudgingly — said yeah, I'm not going to do it, let him do it. So the case in point of the sequence was that it was totally absurd. I mean the scene is that James Bond chases a kidnapped woman through the streets of St. Petersburg in a tank, basically plowing through every building and bar and truck loaded with whatever, you know, water. I mean it's insanity and totally unrealistic. But it also has to be exciting because it's one of the big moments in the film plus there are mounting points of absurdity through the whole thing. So the first absurd thing is it bursts through the wall of the prison, the next absurd thing is it does something else, and then just when you think the whole thing's climaxed it hits a statue and the statue lands on top of the tank as he's driving it. So I mean you can't peak within the first couple of minutes. You have to have excitement but then you have to build the excitement and build the excitement and then build it more. So it's an interesting sequence because it's one of those chases, and we had a similar thing in the new James Bond film that I wrote some brass arrangements for because there's a whole scene in Cuba where there's a big fight. But what they wanted to do was get the sort of salsa/Cuban element into the James Bond/Hans Zimmer milieu. So again it was an absurd moment, that you have to play on and build and stack up, and then we got Arturo Sandoval to play a solo and then we got the big brass section. But it's still recognizably Hans Zimmer's music you know.

MR: That was going through my head there. How much do you have to be aware of what's been written so far by another composer and try not to sound like an obvious change of arranger/composer.

JA: Well particularly on that Bond thing I mentioned the scene, it's the only thing I composed in the film. But because I'd orchestrated the rest of the film I knew tricks that the original composer had used in his score that subconsciously, I mean people probably wouldn't have even realized that I used elements that he had used like certain percussive things like a triangle and — you know subtle touches that would link to what was written in the rest of the score. So you are always thinking in terms of that. You're not going in like the bull in the china shop and going oh, I do it this way so that what you've done is going to stick out like a — I mean it stuck out anyway because there was no other brass in the whole film, and they hadn't used the Bond theme really through the whole film. So suddenly to have a big brass James Bond moment probably stuck out from the rest of the score anyway but there's nothing I could do about that, they wanted big James Bond so I gave it to them.

MR: As an orchestrator do you usually get a piano score? What is given to you?

JA: It depends. I mean there are some composers, for example I orchestrated for Ryuichi Sakamoto who was a genius. He basically could have done it all himself. He sketched it out and sent, you know these days people send synth demos that you take it from. But then I orchestrated for Elmer Bernstein on the film and he gave me like two bars of melody with no key signature and just said, you know, "Do whatever you like, make it sound good."

MR: I hope you got paid more for that one.

JA: Well it was nice, you know, when I got to the studio he said, "Well you know what it sounds like, you go and conduct the band and I'll just sit in the control room." I love working with him because obviously I mean you know, how can you not love working with Elmer Bernstein?

MR: Here's a very specific question: I think you did the music for "Garden of Redemption"?

JA: I did, yeah.

MR: And on the end credits there's this very moving piece of music that probably is as the credits scroll, and you had the melody and I think it was an English horn. Do you recall that?

JA: Yes I do.

MR: Yeah. And then it was passed to the cello. I don't really have a question except it's an observation that it was beautifully done and did you choose the English horn for a particular reason?

JA: Yes is the answer. A very simple answer. I think interestingly, and this is possibly something that doesn't get picked up a lot, as someone who orchestrates and generally orchestrates my own compositions, I always compose thinking of particular sounds or instruments. So to pick a trumpet or an English horn or a French horn or whatever it

might be is always a deliberate thing in the composition process, not even when — so when I orchestrate I actually know what I'm going to be writing rather than oh I wonder what instrument that would sound good on. It's slightly different I think from a lot of composers who would just write something and then oh what can I put this on.

MR: Yeah because then you're running into like that doesn't lie very well on this instrument now I've got to fuss with it.

JA: Very true. Very true. And again, if I'm arranging a pop record for example, I'm always thinking of what the key is, what the vocalist is, and what can surround it in a certain way. So for example an interesting one in terms of the pop music was Rod Stewart's version of "Downtown Train," the Tom Waits song, because we recorded it in the key of G and then he found that his voice — because he'd abstained from smoking and worked out and whatever, it was too low. So they vari-sped it up to B flat. And this was the days before autotune and computerized — I don't know how they did it but what happened was the entire arrangement sounded weird. It worked but it was weird. All the vibratos of the strings and woodwind were wrong. They were ethereal — other worldly. And I'd written for two English horns that were at the top of their range. Once it was pushed up to B flat they were above where they would normally be so if I'd have known I was going to be in B flat I would have written for oboes. If I'd known I was going to be in B flat I wouldn't have written the strings so high but it all worked. So it was serendipity.

MR: Wow. I have never heard of such a thing. And so it didn't speed up the music.

JA: No I don't know how they did it. I mean Trevor Horn who produced it, in his new book, has explained how he did it, which there was some sort of film — something that was used by movie editors that he appropriated and he replaced the arrangement with synthesized — until the point where they could get it to actually sound like it should have done, and then they put back the original chart. I mean it wasn't as simple as tweaking a knob and pushing the whole thing up a tone, or well a tone would have been a lot. But this is a tone and a half. It's insanity.

MR: Are you a patient man?

JA: Yeah.

MR: Because I saw that anecdote about the three hour orchestral session with Bjork that she showed up at the last ten minutes or something and I can imagine that was a pretty tense situation with all those people sitting there and the clock running.

JA: It was but the amazing thing, obviously, because it's you know her singing live with a big band, first take. It's got that excitement of a first take with a big band. And there's no way — well there's no way we could have done it as a backing track with her singing on top of it, but also six takes and the whole level of excitement would have gone right

down. So it was lucky in the end, although I could do without the showing up ten minutes from the end.

MR: Do you find that you have to be a bit of a psychiatrist in working with certain pop musicians?

JA: Definitely. I mean it's very interesting sometimes particularly when you're doing things that are slightly out of their comfort zone. Because although part of it is doing what you do and getting it right, and they've hired you because of what you do, the other part is reassuring them that they're not making a terrible mistake by doing what they've decided to do. And the only real way to do that is to make it as good and as pleasant as possible. So I think in the old days of — which I know from people I've spoken to — of top session players, both here and in Los Angeles and New York, sort of laughing behind their hands at some of the things that they're working on, I could never, you know I had some terrible moments early on, particularly with string sections, older string sections, who really (A) couldn't care less about what they were playing, and (B) actually couldn't play it properly anyway, which is very bizarre. I wrote an arrangement on an early — well I wrote an arrangement on an early record where I had a triplet figure going against the 4/4 rhythm, which really was very simple, it was like [scats]. Couldn't play it. And I couldn't believe it. They could not play it. And then the next time I wrote a string figure that jumped from one octave to like an octave above plus I don't know two notes or whatever it was. And they struggled to the point where one of the string players said to the leader, "Can we change the part?" And the leader went mad and said, "You play it as it's written. You don't mess about with it." So I was doing a session and at the back of the first violins was a 17-year-old violinist who is now a big orchestral leader and conductor. And he called me over and he said, "You don't have to put up with this." He said, "Let me put your sections together." I said, right. You know. Next session, please, you book it. From then on I never had a problem. He booked the most incredible section, young, eager, who actually knew the vocabulary and listened to the music they were recording. That wasn't the case of jaded players looking at their watch, you know, upside down on their arm going, "Right. Pack up. That's the end of the session." Which we had. Not on my session but I saw it happen. A viola player packing up in the middle of a take and walking out.

MR: Whoa.

JA: Unbelievable.

MR: Yeah I had an instant like that once I'll briefly share, doing charts for an Elvis impersonator.

JA: Oh yeah?

MR: And they were doing a "Suspicious Minds" which has this brass part [scats], very simple, right? Rock rhythm. And the fellas that were in the brass section were like old swing guys so it got to that part and they're going [scats]. And I'm going [scats], it's like it was foreign to them to just read.

JA: Yeah you have to be very careful about that. And I was very lucky because there was a whole generation of session players that were coming up when I went in really full pelt. And they all spoke the same language. They listened to the same type of music. So if I wrote — because the worst thing that would happen in the early days was — oh country & western, I can play country & western. Well you can't because you're just playing what you think country & western is. Or oh, funk, yes, I know what funk is. No hang on a minute, that's not what it is. And it's very difficult when you're actually trying to explain to someone that they're actually not correct. I mean I still — when I book an orchestra I'm very, very — I don't know what the word is, but I don't like to correct people and say no you're doing it wrong. Because I'd be offended if somebody said it to me so I'm offended on their behalf of saying, "Excuse me, instead of doing this could you do that?" And luckily I don't have to do that very often because everybody is on the same page as it were.

MR: Yeah I was envious of one of the many videos had you standing in front of a huge orchestra and is there a difference for you — you said when I book an orchestra, which I'm assuming you're booking only the instrumentalists that you want, that you wrote for. So if you get a commission to write for a full orchestra have you ever had the issue of there's more instruments here than I really need but I better write something for the second bassoon because they've been sitting there for a long time?

JA: I know what you mean. No, it never really comes up, you know because if you're given the orchestral resource, I mean for example I wrote something for a community orchestra in the Midlands, and they said well we've got like 18 flute players or something like that, and one violin. So what you write is actually based on what their line-up is. And it's interesting because it then becomes a challenge. You think what am I doing to do with all these people? How am I going to — and the ones who can't actually play as well as the other ones, do I write the same things for them? So there are different challenges. But I've been so lucky because when I write for orchestra if it's not my own selection of players I've written for the LSO and for the Royal Philharmonic and the London Philharmonic and the Philharmonia and the Birmingham Symphony. So I know what I'm going to get you know. I know that whatever I write will be played exactly as I've written it. I'm not going to have to go in and say, "Hang on a minute, this is all wrong."

MR: Do you ever walk around the orchestra when they're rehearsing and you're hearing something that's awry.

JA: Oh yeah.

MR: Perhaps a copyist mistake?

JA: Totally. It happens quite frequently. You know it's not so prevalent these days because now music copying is off Sibelius and very rarely things go down incorrectly. I mean I was always amazed to see, years ago, Gil Evans' parts and there are mistakes still there on the parts. "Oh, that's not right." You know, nobody's ever bothered to correct it. Maybe they did in their head but they haven't corrected it on the paper.

MR: That makes me think, someone I interviewed recently was talking about the Gil Evans sound and the fact — and he said, "Well he wrote half steps in the middle of the chord sometimes." Now I'm starting to think well maybe not on purpose.

JA: Well I'll never forget when he was rehearsing in London the trumpet player said, "Gil my part is a bit high." And Gil said to him, "Oh, play it two octaves lower then." Wonderful.

MR: Am I correct that American film producers and directors often come to London to record partly because it's more economically feasible for them?

JA: That is a part of it because there are no residuals on film recording in the U.K. So the big — I mean it's a double-edged thing. They think that the orchestras are better in London and quicker, their reading is quicker, their interpretation is quicker. But also there are no residuals so that becomes a big thing in their thinking.

MR: Is it common in England for English films for the musicians to get credit in the scroll?

JA: It's starting to happen. It's happening a lot now — I think it's become a mandatory thing in American movies, to credit the musicians. In my experience there are directors who I've worked with who insist on crediting people, and there are who don't. I mean I've just done a film, I think everybody's credited. I haven't seen it yet but I suspect everyone has been credited.

MR: Speaking of haven't seen it yet, do you — at what point before the actual end of a film do you get to see the film and the music together and is there anything that you have the ability to say that's not what I had in mind?

JA: Usually you get to the cast and crew you know. A very interesting one is actually "Life of Brian." Because obviously I did the arrangement of "Always Look on the Bright Side of Life" that finishes the film. And I went to the preview and my whole arrangement apart from the rhythm track, it vanished. There was a saxophone solo and a trumpet solo. And being the last thing in the film I was really looking forward to it and I was really depressed. I came out, oh dear you know. But okay that's what they've chosen to do. I then got invited to the premier and my whole arrangement had been put back, everything. And years later I found out that George Harrison, who produced the film, insisted that my arrangement be restored into the film. So thank you, George.

MR: Thank you, George. Over here we have a term called train wrecks where things just go really badly. Is there anything that pops into your head?

JA: Oh God, not half. So we were doing a film, "Funny Bones" which is a wonderful comedy with Jerry Lewis and Oliver Platt and Lee Evans and Leslie Caron. And I had written basically an orchestral score with two percussionists. And I had in mind the sound of Weather Report for the rhythm. So I booked Alex Acuna and Michael Fisher in Los Angeles. And we couldn't find the studio and we finally found one because we were ringing them up and saying, "Are you able to show PAL videos?" PAL videos of course were British standard, not NTSC pneumatics but PAL. And everyone said, "Sorry, no we can't do it, sorry." One studio said, "Yeah, no problem." So we showed up at the studio and the first thing, the truck — it was in the basement. The truck with all the percussion couldn't get into the car park. That was the start. They started unloading stuff and the studio was locked. So it all had to pile up in the car park. Then the guy turned up, not the engineer but the guy who ran the studio turned up and he had a baseball cap on backwards, which I thought oh this is not going to go well. Finally we got in and they couldn't — they'd never recorded a live instrument. They'd only plugged in guitars into the desk. So they couldn't get the microphone lead to stretch into the studio to clip on to the microphone to get it recorded. Then we found out that, "Have you got a PAL video" the guy thought he'd said "Have you got a video, pal?" And of course there wasn't a PAL video in sight so we couldn't look at the film. So the whole first session was attempting to stretch a lead to the microphone into the room with no picture whatsoever. And at one point I went outside and the engineer, a very famous movie soundtrack engineer, and my producer were on — they had their heads on adjacent wheelie bins sobbing, literally in tears. I went back in and the director was sitting in the back of me and he went, "It's all going terribly well." Somehow we persuaded them to stay for another three hours and we actually got it going. And there was no orchestral track obviously, this is pre the orchestra. And I had my timings. So they recorded to my timings. Then we got ready to take the tape back to London and the guy in the studio said, "You've got a problem here because they haven't given you enough run-up to synchronize the music to the film." So my producer on the last day when we were due to fly back to England and had a rush to a film facility where they inserted blank tape into the recording. And we got back to London thinking well tough, we've blown the whole thing. And it worked. Everything fitted. But that was just about the — that was the car crash. That was the car crash session.

MR: Talk about improvising.

JA: Oh the other car crash session was for Elliott Lawrence where it was a Ford commercial for a Super Bowl and it was 20 minutes long, I think six films of four minutes

interspersed through the thing. And the Monday we were recording with the symphony orchestra. On the Friday afternoon the engineer — the assistant editor phoned me, sorry not the engineer. And he said, "I think you've been sent the wrong tape." So I had to look at it and what he said was — not the right tape — he was right, it was the wrong tape. And I said, "Well how am I supposed to write?" He said, "Well I've just been fired so I can't help you." So obviously he'd done it in revenge because the guy had, you know the main editor had fired him. He gave me a phone number for the head of Ford or something like that, where the producer was spending the weekend in the Catskills. So I telephoned from London to the Catskills to say I think I've got the wrong, you sent me the wrong tape. And the guy was obviously sitting with the boss so he was going, "Oh, no problem at all." I go, "Yes there is a problem, I can't write because I've got the wrong — I haven't got any sync points. "Yes well that's great. We look forward to hearing it on Monday." I go, "No you don't understand, I can't do it." And he's covering the phone. Anyway he hangs up and in comes Elliott Lawrence with the guy from the agency and I rang him and said, "Elliott we've got a big problem, you know we can't really do it because it's all wrong." And he said, "Well a couple of them are right so just do them." Okay so we get to the studio and we do the ones that are correct. And I got to the control room and there's the boss of the agency and Elliott Lawrence and they're going, "Oh this reminds me of the time we did the so-and-so commercial and they sent the wrong film, ha-ha-ha-ha." "And what about the time this happened ha-ha-ha-ha-ha." And I'm sweating, you know because I couldn't do it. And they're laughing it off. And then at the end of the week we got the correct cuts and we did the rest of it, you know and it went on. But oh. I aged about ten years.

MR: I was going to say, that ages you. That's fascinating stuff. Just a couple more things here. You had made a statement I believe you were taking about the song "Rock Around the Clock" that there was very little teenage music before that. I'm fascinated by that transition from what we'll call swing into rock and it's always struck me that "Rock Around the Clock" is actually a swing tune.

JA: Oh totally. And I got to — which, I think I probably mentioned or you might know, when they had 50 years of "Blackboard Jungle" I got to play with the original Comets so it's basically everybody who was on the original record apart from Bill Haley and my friend Billy Gusack who played drums because they reckoned that the drummer, Dick, sped up, so they wanted someone to keep the tempo. Anyway so it was basically the original band that toured with Bill Haley. And they played "Shake, Rattle & Roll," Franny Beecher was there, a great jazz guitarist, Joey Ambrose, the great jazz tenor player, Marshall Little, you know they were all swing musicians, western swing. And they swung like crazy. I mean I got to play on two or three numbers but their basic repertoire was "Rock Around

the Clock" and "Shake, Rattle & Roll" and all these things, were western swing. Absolutely. And the whole rhythmic feel was totally different to that sort of [scats] rock & roll thing that everybody thought straight eighths. It was swing. And it was so infectious, it was incredible. And you could say yeah, this is why they succeeded you know. It was in that tradition. It was swing.

MR: Yeah, so when you watch videos of people doing the Lindy hop at the Savoy there's really not that much difference from what Bill Haley's that swing, western swing feel was happening.

JA: Absolutely. I agree. And that's — I particularly noticed it when they played "Shake, Rattle & Roll" because you get your perception of what it sounded like with Joe Turner and then what it sounded like later. And this was down another path. This really was western swing which of course Joe Turner wasn't. Joe was R&B and the western swing feel is different from the R&B feel. So it was very interesting to get that and to play with it. Marvelous.

MR: When you get up from this session, will music — a musical task come back into your head?

JA: I'm sure it will. I mean I've just done some charts, I've got a big band gig coming up — well two — in a couple of weeks. So I've just continued what I've been doing which is adapting hit records that I've had into big band settings. So I know nobody else is going anywhere near them.

MR: I wanted to make a comment that I was watching a video of you and a big band and you were playing "I Wish I Knew." And you were playing your curved soprano and I just wanted you to know that your quote in your solo of "Honeysuckle Rose" was noticed.

JA: Well that's good, yes. I mean sometimes — well I mean quotes are sort of — I'm not on Sonny Rollins' sort of level of quotes, but —

MR: But it's an interesting process because you have to realize how do I fit this particular tune into this particular key? Right? It's a mental gymnastics sort of thing.

JA: Yeah, well the great one is — oh no, it's one of the Christmas numbers that Chet Baker plays "June in January" in. I'm trying to remember which one. But it's quite startling you know. Paul Desmond was the master of that.

MR: Oh yes. Your career has gone from splicing tape and using a pencil and pad to today where things seem to change almost every year. Are there positives and negatives for you?

JA: Yeah I think so. I mean I still try to put, if I'm composing, ideas down on paper and then transfer them to the computer. When I'm arranging lately I've done a lot more, although I'm sort of sketching stuff out, a lot more of the basic work I've been doing on the computer rather than on manuscript. But I'd like to say I miss that old way of doing it,

but I don't think I really miss it. I don't think that's the right sentence. All that drudgery. Plus the fact that I wound up in the position where I couldn't read my own writing so I don't know how anyone else did. It's got worse and worst. My copyist used to say, "I can read your musical stuff but it's the directions that I haven't a clue what you've written — make a guess at, does that say 'adagio' or 'allegro' or what does it say?"

MR: Does that say PAL or does that say something else.

JA: Yes. "Have you got a video, pal." Funny.

MR: Last question. Of all the things you've done from going into clubs and sitting in to standing in front of a 60-piece orchestra, is there a through line through that? Is there something that is always a constant for you?

JA: Gee. I mean I'm just totally enamored of making music in some way. So to stand in front of my quartet and play, "I Wish I Knew" or an obscure standard is just as exciting as doing a downbeat in front of the London Symphony Orchestra. It's a different excitement I guess. But it's still an extension of exactly where I was when I started, which not a lot of people can say that. The one thing that — when I saw my uncle a lot when he moved to America and I was in America, and he was basically conducting for Milton Berle and Anthony Newley and Donald O'Connor and, you know, doing a lot of variety stuff. And he said to me — he was a great trombone player, recorded with Coleman Hawkins in the '30s and he said, "Have you given up playing yet?" And I said, "No." He said, "You will." I said, "No, I won't." So it made me more determined to keep the playing going. Because he'd put his trombone behind the chair and forgotten about it. And that's I guess a lot of arrangers' lot isn't it, that they stop playing because they just don't have time to devote to it. I mean I stopped playing flute and clarinet possibly for that reason, but I never wanted to stop playing saxophone or playing in public or you know having a jazz group or using the jazz brain.

MR: I'd like to think that that's important, that you're still connected in a physical way to the players who are making your music come alive, and you still know what that feels like.

JA: Oh I'm always conscious of it, particularly, you know the interesting thing, somebody said, "Why don't you feature yourself more with your big band?" And I said, "Because there are five saxophone players who are better than me and I want to hear them." You know I don't mind playing three numbers in the whole show, you know that's fine as long as I can hear some of these brilliant players. And I had a big band in L.A. and a big band in Australia and one is the U.K. and they're all fantastic. You know when you've got Pete Christlieb or Plas Johnson or Bob Efford sitting there, you're not going to hog every solo. There's no way. Or Lanny Morgan. You know it's insanity to think — well you know what, I'm going to feature myself now, never mind those people.

MR: Well I suspect you're running out of room in your house for the mementos and awards and all that.

JA: Yeah.

MR: It's been a fascinating conversation and I'm very appreciative of your time.

JA: Well it's been my pleasure, I've thoroughly enjoyed it.

MR: Excellent. So I'll just pause us here and we'll say our good-byes. Thanks, John.